



Uncertainties prevail:

Mohammedan SC (in black) is a doubtful participant for the next season if it fails to find a sponsor and meet the league's financial criteria. FSDL

But there appears to be no definite pathway or track record in the ISL for them to make that step up. It took until the seventh season before an Indian was appointed in a permanent head coach role.

Among the 84 permanent head coach appointments in the ISL, there have been just two Indians — Khalid Jamil (NorthEast United in 2021; **right**) and Thangboi Singto (Hyderabad FC in 2023).

At the end of the 2024-25 season, the ISL — the country's top-flight competition from 2019-20 — is at crossroads.

After kicking off amid frenzied fanfare in 2014, the endeavour has become a loss-making exercise for the clubs involved.

There is no certainty over

relegation being introduced next season as charted in the AFC-AIFF roadmap, while financial struggles continue to plague clubs.

After Hyderabad FC's turmoil in recent seasons, Mohammedan SC, who was promoted last year, is a doubtful participant for the next season if it fails to find a sponsor and meet the league's financial criteria.

The viability of the league has also come into question with the Master Rights Agreement between the national federation and its commercial partner, Football Sports Development League (FSDL), ending in December this year.

The league's operational costs since 2014 have allegedly led to a loss of over ₹5,000 crores for the FSDL. Unless all stakeholders at the table strike a deal on a sustainable model, the competition will remain under a cloud.

And amid the lack of resolution from the top on the future of the ISL, Indian football will not be able to look past Chhetri as its main man.



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